

**FILM AND THE HUNGARIAN GOVERNMENT'S 'CULTURE WAR' – CHANGING THE INTELLECTUAL
ELITE BASED ON AN IDEOLOGY**

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Introduction to the Industry

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Changing the Intellectual Elite Based on an Ideology

Since 2010, Hungary has been governed by the same right-wing political party, Fidesz¹, and in every cycle, led by the same prime minister, Viktor Orbán. Over the past decade, he created an illiberal democracy, a populist, Eurosceptic, national Christian-conservative regime that they call the 'System of National Cooperation' (NER), or as Heller calls it, a new 'tyranny' (2019, p.14). "Fidesz is a centralized party, which has become more and more equivalent to Orbán; it would not exist without him" (Heller, 2019, p.6).

Under the so-called Orbán-regime, a strong centralization has taken place in every area, the ongoing battle is over culture now. Following his victory in the third electoral cycle with a two-thirds majority as a result of a biased electoral system, Orbán summed up the aims of his system in his speech:

And our two-thirds victory in 2018 is nothing short of a mandate to build a new era. (...) A political regime is usually determined by rules and political decisions. An era, however, is more than this. An era is determined by cultural trends, collective beliefs and social customs. This is now the task we are faced with: we must embed the political system in a cultural era. (...) Next May we can wave goodbye not only to liberal democracy and the liberal non-democratic system that has been built on its foundations but also to the entire elite of '68. (Orbán, Tusnádfürdő, minisztelenok.hu, 2018).

Cultural Policy

Orbán started an overt attack on the cultural sector by distributing public money based on political criteria (Bajomi et al., 2020, pp.7-8) and was meant to achieve the replacement of the elites (Bozóki, 2013). "Orbán simply could not tolerate a sphere of life that is not controlled by him. (...) They can destroy, or at least try to destroy, the existing culture and create a so-called culture for

¹ Party of the Young Democrats

writers, artists, and scientists who belong to their own camp” (Heller, 2019, p.18). The National Cultural Fund (NKA) was a self-governing, financially independent body and the main financial source of cultural and non-governmental organizations until it was merged under a ministry² in 2016 therefore its autonomy was turned down (Szaniszló, 2016, pp.205-206). Likewise, the most important income source of independent theatres, the Corporate Tax (TAO) was taken away, which made them impossible to function, and government-loyal persons were appointed to the management of many theatres, claiming that the right-wing also need a theatre. (Bajomi, 2020, p.56). The National Theater’s chief director³ was dismissed because he could not authentically represent the national values, and his ‘unpatriotic’ productions doesn’t fit in there. (Bozoki, 2017, p.7). MMA, the Hungarian Academy of Arts is a collective of representatives of national artists⁴ - became also an openly right-wing guild, sometimes simply called Orbán’s Academy. Financially highly supported by the government and its members condemn liberal thoughts in arts: "So far, a liberal minority has wanted to define what Hungarian art is, it's time to change that" (Népszava, 2017).

Film Industry

The film industry has seemed to be an exception from the ideological control for long, but presumably, it is time for politics and propaganda to sneak into this field too. National Film Fund (2011-2019) was the main financial source for filmmaking, led by Hungarian-born American film producer Andy Vajna⁵ appointed as Government Commissioner for Film. He was maintaining a good relationship with Orbán and openly supported Fidesz. However, the film industry kept its autonomy, an independent committee of highly ranked professionals distributed the public funds (the main and

² EMMI – Ministry of Human Resources – responsible for sports, culture, health, education, families, social issues and many other areas. Its minister is Miklós Kásler.

³ Róbert Alföldi was replaced by Attila Vidnyánszky as chief director of the National Theater in 2013

⁴ MMA is responsible for arts, especially literature, music, fine arts, applied arts, design art, as well as architecture, photography, film, performing arts, folk art - as well as art analysis, support and education

⁵ Producer of Rambo, Terminator, Evita

only financial source of domestic filmmaking), mostly free from party politics. After Vajna died in 2019, the Film Fund was reorganized under the name of the National Film Institute (NFI) which is responsible for the coordinated activities of the entire Hungarian film industry. At first, it seemed that no radical change will come, but now we can observe some warning signs that the film industry might be the new target of government propaganda and censorship, and the new film commissioner⁶, whose loyalty is unquestionable to Fidesz (Sajó, index.hu 2019) doesn't have the same charisma or will to prevent the industry from politics. "We want the film industry to be one of the key sources of our national identity" - as it was written in the text of the proposal of the new film law, submitted by Zsolt Semjén⁷ (Tbg, 444.hu, 2019).

Since then, many projects that have already been under development during the Vajna-era hasn't got the support for the production eventually. There is no logical reason for that, planting huge efforts and money on script development and pre-production than cancelling the actual production. This had rarely happened before, and the only explanation is the radical change in the decision-making board's view. NFI has shut down already supported projects or rejected scripts of highly respected, experienced and award-winning directors⁸ (Bodnár, J.L., 24.hu, 2020). Meanwhile, others became highly supported by the Film Institute⁹. "The National Film Institute divides the money into a defined narrow circle, we can get acquainted with the names of new directors and producers we have never heard before" - said András Muhi (2021, hvg.hu) independent producer. It is presumable, that politics tries to change the composition of the artistic elite in the film industry – just like in many other areas - by punishing the liberal artists and excluding them from the industry while promoting the ones who share ideology with them regardless of their professional

⁶ Csaba Káel followed Vajna as Film Commissioner. He is also a Fidesz-friendly figure he directed the audiovisual campaign of the party in 1994, 1998 and 2002

⁷ Deputy Prime Minister

⁸ like György Pálfi, Attila Szász, Tamás Almási, György Sopsits, Virág Zoborác, Gábor Reisz, Benedek Fliegauf, Dénes Orosz or Attila Árpá

⁹ Tamás Lajos and Norbert Köbli won financial support to four of their projects lately. Other highly promoted producers were Gábor Kálomista and Gábor Ferenczy. Also pro-government actors, musicians are about to make their debut films financed by NFI

achievements. This could cause deterioration of quality and diversity in the future of the Hungarian film industry, by undermining some of the criteria of the economic growth defined by R. Florida (2003) such as tolerance, talent, openness and diversity (pp.37-39).

Hungarian society was always divided by left and right-wing ideology, but it was moderate within the professional film industry. Thanks to the Orbán regime this gap deepens further and serious tension arises among filmmakers and artists, dividing this small society.

Elxrtuk – a Propagandistic Movie

To stand as an example for ideological filmmaking is a recently premiered feature film *Elxrtuk* (English, K., 2021), a political thriller based on real events but spiced up with fictional elements, raising memory for the previous prime minister's fall¹⁰. The movie works as great propaganda and a campaign tool for the ongoing electoral campaign for 2022, suggesting the same message as the government's communication, a hate campaign against the former prime minister and his wife, who represent the whole opposition according to them.

The movie was produced by Gábor Kálmista¹¹ claiming that the movie was financed by private money, namely by his company's savings and bank loans, and also from resources of secret sponsors (Víg, index.hu, 2021) – supposedly oligarch-allies of Orbán. Free screenings all over the country were announced at the first weekend even offering free bus rides (Bod T., Béres M. magyarnarancs.hu, 2021 and HVG, hvg.hu 2021) which is proof of the producers not relying on economic profit, but evidence for being only a political propaganda tool aiming to reach as many citizens as possible, targeting younger generations too.

¹⁰ Which happened because of the infamous 'Őszöd-speech' (2006), an internal private speech of former prime minister Ferenc Gyurcsány leaked out, in which he claims that they were lying to the people in the past years, and they screwed it up, but he wants to change that – this is the main topic of the film.

¹¹ one of the biggest winner and servant of the Orbán regime - gained prominence in a number of different areas such as movies, television, theatre, and festivals

On top of all, the movie received an “art” certificate which is given by NFI¹² to the films “that artistic values contribute to the advancement of Hungarian, European and universal audio-visual culture, or which the Committee finds significant or of high artistic quality, whether from an educational or cultural standpoint.” (NMHH, 2020) - which is highly questionable¹³. It proves that NFI is no longer independent, this rating has only one function, as the film’s producer noted “The barrier to art cinemas screening *Elk*rtuk* has been removed” (Kálomista as cited in origo.hu 2021) so the movie is being screened many times a day in literally all the cinemas in the country from multiplex to art cinemas competing Hollywood blockbusters.

A huge government-friendly media marketing campaign surrounded the movie; numerous billboards¹⁴ are promoting the film, its representation in public news media is exceptional too, the national news program¹⁵ mentioned and promoted the movie many times in the past months (M1-híradó, YouTube). Moreover, the interpreter was talking about the movie’s fictional plot as a fact (Farkas, 24.hu, 2021).

SZFE (University of Theatre and Film Arts)

The government enacted The Higher Education Act (2012) which states the intellectual and spiritual renewal of the nation (Bajomi, 2020, p.37). With the model change of the financing system of the universities, they became dependent on private foundations with appointed Fidesz-friendly presidents.

The Magna Charta Universitatum (1988) was signed by most of the Hungarian higher education institutes, including SZFE which is the alma mater of the Hungarian artistic and intellectual

¹² National Film Institute – mentioned above

¹³ The movie’s IMDB ranking as of now (2021. November) is 1.4 stars out of 10

¹⁴ Previously those billboards were full of the simplified propaganda messages of the government

¹⁵ The government controls more than 50% of the press, written and online news media, and TV and radio channels. The status of media freedom has been internationally downgraded by press freedom watch organizations, Hungary is listed as partly free. (Freedom House, 2021).

elite for 150 years. The first fundamental principle of the Charta is “The university is an autonomous institution (...) its research and teaching must be morally and intellectually independent of all political authority and economic power” (MCU, 1988). Despite this, what is happening with the ‘model change of Hungarian universities is merely against this principle. Regardless of the protest of the students and professors at SZFE, the government violently reorganized and privatized the university without any democratic dialogue. The government media was loud of the news that the so-called ‘liberal nest’ should be liquidated and accused the university that ideological training took place, which does not contribute to the “transmission of national identity” (Reviczky, hvg.hu, 2020). The president of the foundation¹⁶ that maintains the University were claiming the favourite conspiracy theory of the government that a liberal circle, a serious international background power and network have been organizing and the students were viciously manipulated by the left-wing liberals who couldn’t accept that they are not in power (Vidnyánszky as cited in Herczeg, 444.hu, 2020). The students were openly refused this accusation and defended the institute’s reputation for all costs. After 71 days of physically blockading the building of the university preventing it from the new management to enter, in 2020 the pandemic took an end to the protests, and the university officially went through privatization. A new senate stood up, and almost all the students and professors had left the institute voluntarily (Kiss, 444.hu, 2021). Most of the students finished their studies privately within the newly established FreeSZFE Association and received their diplomas from foreign universities¹⁷. In the first year of the new administration, the applicants' number to the institute fell dramatically, however it was one of the most overapplied universities before (Flachner, telex.hu, 2021).

¹⁶ Attila Vidnyánszky, he is the government’s appointed chief director of the National Theater too

¹⁷ Universities took place in the ‘*Emergency Exit*’ program from Salzburg (Austria), Ludwigsburg (Germany), Warsaw (Poland), Versico (Switzerland)

Conclusion

In the last decade of Orbán administration having an outright majority in the parliament, an enormous centralization took place in economics, education, media and the cultural sector. Orbán appointed Fidesz-friendly, obedient persons to every decision making position, produces his oligarch-allies by setting up a mafia-state and trying to create a loyal artistic elite while executing liberal artists from the cultural space. Lately, we can see worrying signs that the government finding its way to control the film industry too. We can observe selective distribution of state funds and narrowing opportunities for already proven and respected creators while a certain circle of people are getting the majority of financial support. The selection criteria are sadly not based on professional qualities but ideological reasons, as the government aims to make film as a source of the national identity and transmit national conservative, Christian values or even government propaganda through films, while communicating fanatic hate towards liberalism, liberal thoughts and liberal artists. This process could cause serious harm and deterioration in the creative sector because it ceases diversity, freedom of arts, education and thoughts.

We can only hope that complete dominance could not prevail in the film industry or the creative and cultural sector. Despite the repression, art is something that cannot be controlled entirely, and Orbán and his regime are facing an extreme resistance sourced from the deepest instinct of people, as we had seen from the protesting students of SZFE, the upcoming generation of intellectuals who ended their fight with the following message:

“We are not giving up the blockade, we are taking it with us. (...) And the blockade will last until the political repression ends” (Nagy, artportal, 2011).

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